slow separation of government administration from the CCP, China began a return to what the sinologist David Shambaugh calls "hard authoritarianism" in 2009, during the leadership of Hu Jintao.[18] Hu's successor, current CCP general secretary and Chinese president Xi Jinping, accelerated Beijing's adversarial and repressive policies on taking power in late 2012, responding to a sense of crisis within the CCP over corruption, lack of ideological clarity, and too much liberalization.[19] Xi's repeated invocations of the "Chinese Dream" being the "great rejuvenation of the Chinese people" draw freely on concepts of Han nationalism, including references to Confucianism. Yet these overlay a very traditional legalist approach to society, in which hierarchy is underpinned by strict state control.[20]

Alternative visions of Chinese society, such as those offered by the student activists of the 1919 May Fourth Movement or the 1989 Tiananmen Square democracy demonstrations, are thoroughly suppressed. In foreign affairs, "Xi Jinping Thought on Diplomacy," which was unveiled in 2018, sets the guidelines for the country's overseas relations, in which China's "major-country diplomacy . . . is tasked with realizing the rejuvenation of the Chinese nation."[21] As this entails diplomacy "based on the focal points of the work of the party and the country," according to leading diplomat Yang Jiechi, Chinese diplomacy is thus subordinated to CCP goals of ensuring the triumph of Chinese socialism over the capitalist system.[22] In other words, despite platitudes that Beijing is committed to global development and progress, diplomacy is about strengthening China.

The China that has emerged after nearly a half century of engagement with the West is more suspicious, less satisfied, less cooperative, and less liberal than its eager American interlocutors hoped it would be. Americans and others are finally accepting this reality, disappointed though they might be and as split as they are on how to deal with China going forward, not least among the China-watching community.[23] No longer is Beijing portrayed in Washington as a "responsible stakeholder," nor do many hold out hope that an effective G-2 might yet emerge. Indeed, the specter of a second Cold War increasingly shapes